



THE TRANS NEWS INITIATIVE

A WHITE PAPER FOR JOURNALISTS, MEDIA RESEARCHERS,
COMMUNITY ORGANIZERS & MORE

[TRANSNEWSINITIATIVE.ORG](https://transnewsinitiative.org)

TABLE OF CONTENTS

INTRODUCTION	PAGE 1
TOOL ORIENTATION	PAGE 3
METHODS	PAGE 6
DATA HIGHLIGHTS	PAGE 9
AUDIENCES & UTILITIES	PAGE 13
EARLY LEARNINGS	PAGE 15
FUTURE DEVELOPMENT OPPORTUNITIES	PAGE 16
TRANS NEWS COLLABORATORS	PAGE 17

INTRODUCTION

Trans people and our place in society are at the center of a fierce political debate, legislative attacks, and widespread misinformation. As public discourse shapes policy and perception, the accuracy of news coverage matters more than ever.

That is where the [Trans News Initiative](#) comes in.

A collaboration between the Trans Journalists Association (TJA), the University of Miami School of Communication, and data journalism studio Polygraph, the Trans News Initiative tracks and analyzes mainstream news coverage of trans communities across the United States. A growing catalog of more than 190,500 articles about trans communities, the [first-of-its-kind tool](#) provides ongoing data and in-depth analysis that empowers reporters, media organizations, researchers, community organizers, and more to understand how stories about trans people are being told – and [where coverage falls short in major media sources](#).

The TJA is building a future of journalism where stories about trans people are just, ethical, and informed by our leadership. As the only trans-led organization working to foster better news coverage of issues impacting trans rights and communities, and to improve the experiences of trans people working in journalism, we promote accurate, nuanced coverage through our Stylebook and Coverage Guide, timely coverage guidances and research briefs, newsroom trainings, and more. Founded in 2020, we support the careers of transgender and otherwise gender expansive journalists through our Workplace Resources Guide, regular members-only skills-building workshops, professional development investment, and other programs and activities.

The Trans News Initiative was born out of a connection between Alberto Cairo, who serves as the Knight Chair in Infographics and Data Visualization at the University of Miami School of Communication, and noted journalist and editor Gina Chua, who is also a board member of the TJA. Informally, Cairo had been keeping personal notes of instances of media coverage of trans people that were failures, which is to say

articles that should not be lifted up as aspirational pieces of journalism. The TJA, as an industry watchdog, had been doing the same: following inaccurate and misleading coverage and ideating on resources that could meaningfully shift how trans people are covered toward reporting that honors our community's humanity.

What remains clear is that though journalists who are trans and those who cover issues impacting LGBTQ+ communities might be familiar with community-informed best practices, **most coverage that reaches news consumers is not made with trans people in mind.** A separate analysis of stories covering the first 100 days of the second Trump administration by the TJA and Berkeley Media Studies Group noted 70% of the articles did not feature a single trans person. Most stories quoted at least one cisgender politician, but no trans people. Only a fraction of stories quoted representatives from trans organizations; even fewer quoted trans youth.

In such an environment, we know that there are consequences. But in response to this media problem, the TJA is often peppered with questions about data: How often are mainstream outlets writing about trans people? Which outlets are running those stories and which aren't? What exactly do those stories cover? What stories aren't being covered as regularly?

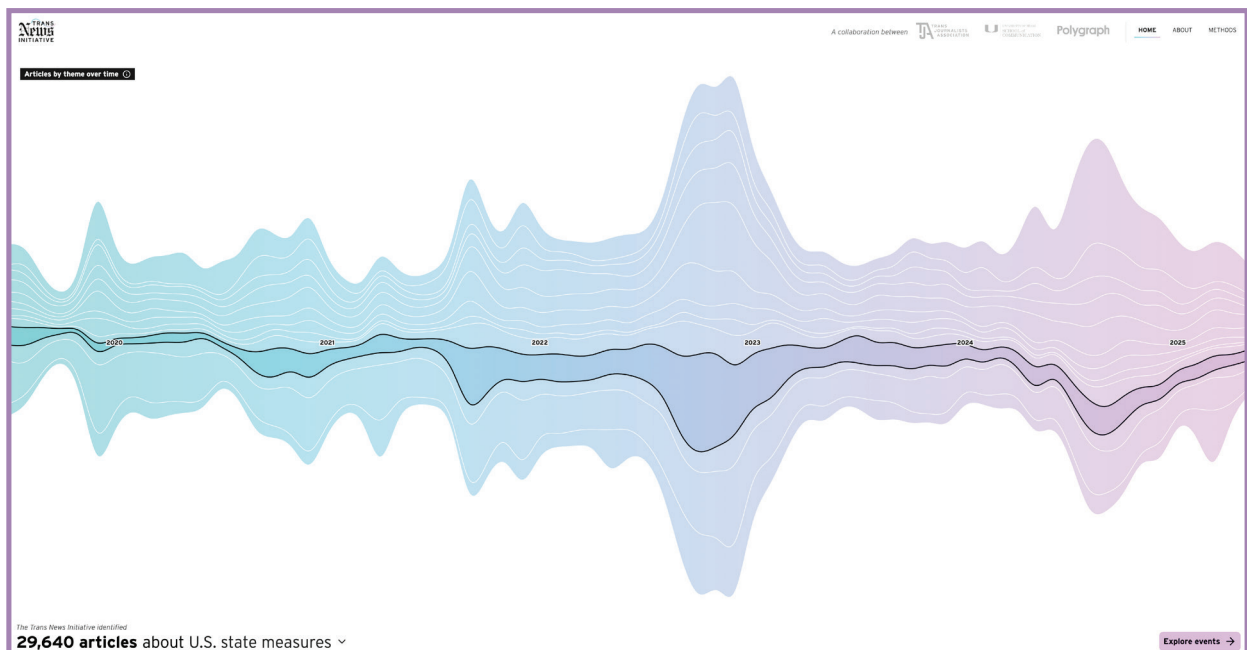
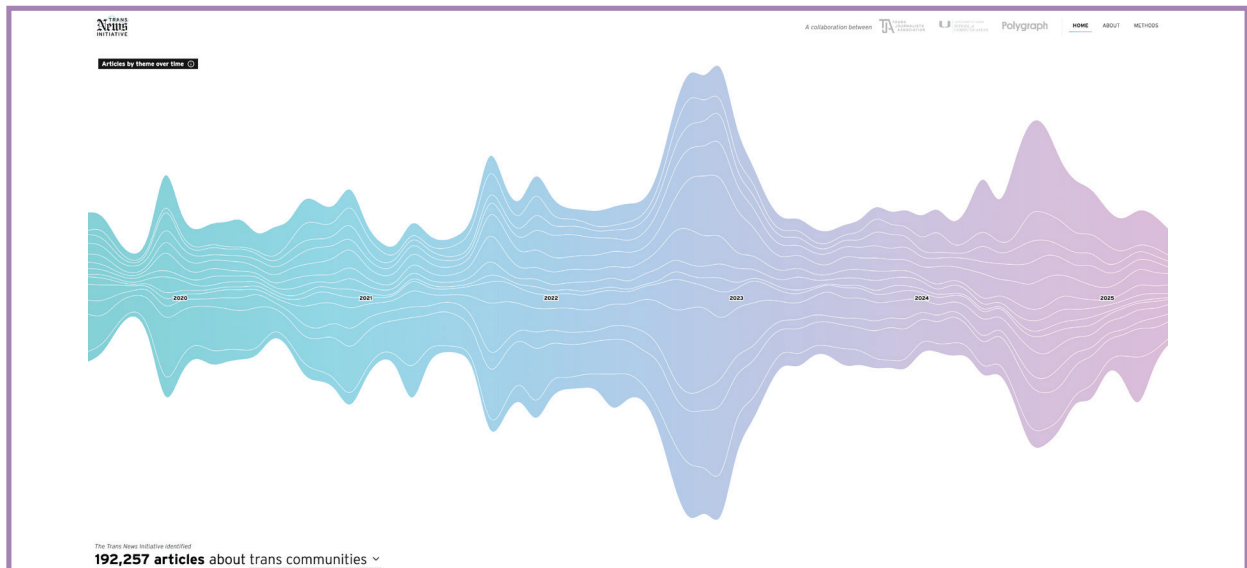
The Trans News Initiative houses that data, serving both as a tool that helps us articulate the scale of the problem – **and as a solution.**



The logo of the Trans News Initiative incorporates a font inspired by traditional newsprint and the editing/proofreading symbol meaning to transpose or change the order. It also uses colors of the trans pride flag.

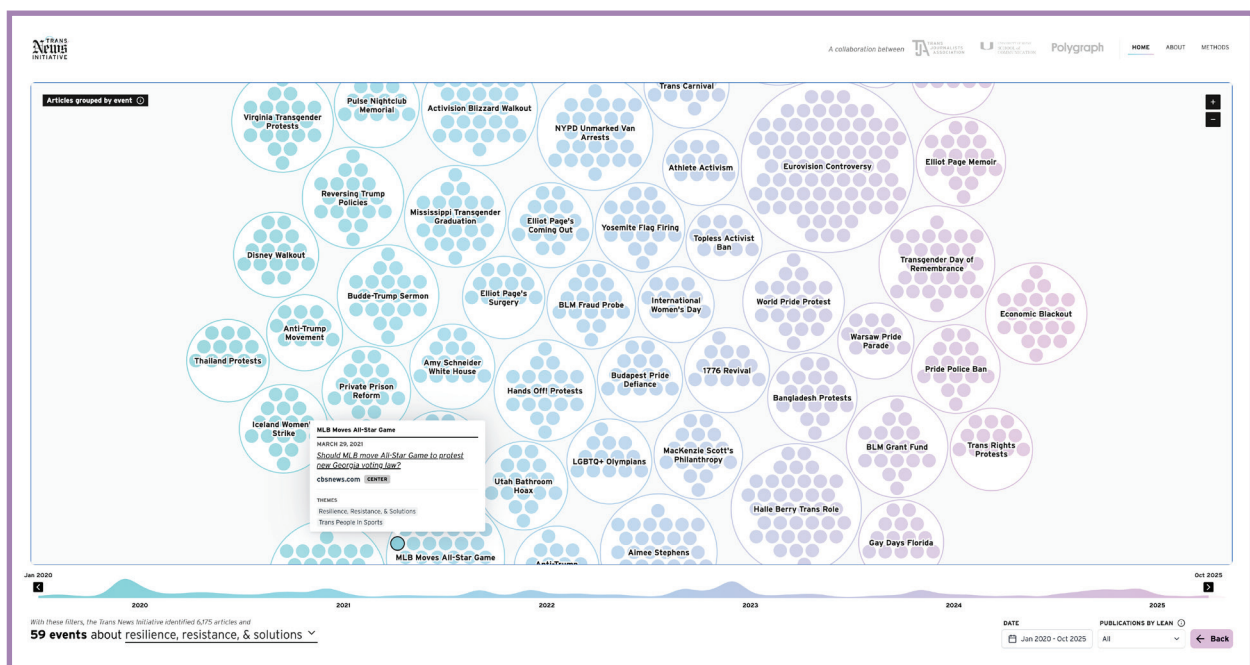
TOOL ORIENTATION

The homepage of TNI is a streamgraph, which is a variation of a stacked area chart. Instead of plotting values against a fixed baseline Y axis, the stacks or streams bulge from the center. This chart shows the number of total news articles about trans communities across 13 overarching themes over time. [At initial publication, the tool cataloged 190,561 articles about trans communities.](#)



Each stream in the streamgraph represents a different theme, which include “anti-trans violence & hate,” “health care & bodily autonomy,” and “U.S. state measures,” among others. The taller the stream, the more articles cataloged under said theme. The themes can be identified by hovering over each stream, or toggling between them in the bottom left corner. Clicking on a stream brings up the articles cataloged within it. Some stories may appear in multiple streams.

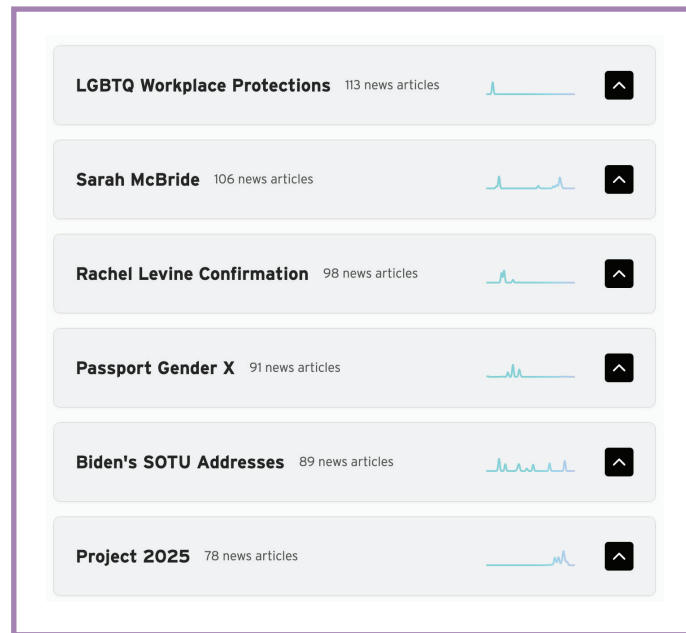
Each theme stream has its own packed circle chart (pictured below) that groups articles (filled dots) into events (surrounding circles). The larger the event circles, the more articles were published about the event, which reflects overall news coverage.



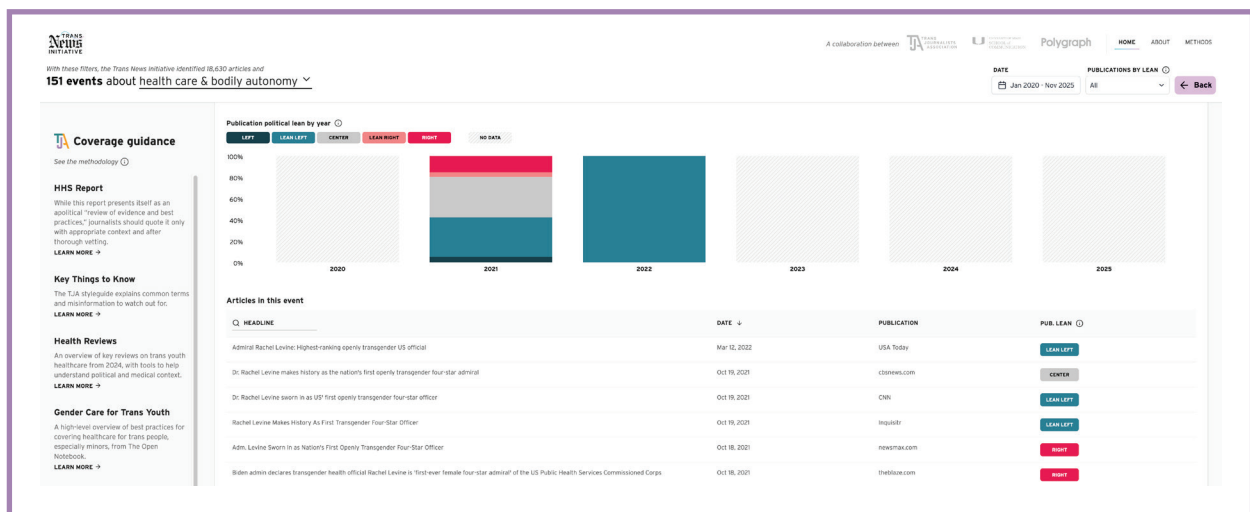
Hovering or tapping on each dot reveals specific article information. Below the chart is a slider that can be used to adjust the coverage timeframe.

The events cataloged within each theme are also listed directly below the packed circle chart. Toggling through each theme reveals a beeswarm chart reflecting coverage frequency, a political lean meter, and a searchable listing of all the associated articles in the selected dataset.

Right: Each cataloged event within the data lists a tally of its total number of articles as well as a coverage timeline reflecting the frequency with which the event has been covered since 2020.



Under the Coverage Guidance header (on left), find relevant best practice information directly from the TJA Stylebook and Coverage Guide, our topical reporting briefs, and other resources linked.



METHODS

INITIAL ARTICLE COLLECTION

To gather the initial list of trans-related news articles, the Trans News Initiative used Media Cloud, an open-source media research project by the Media Ecosystems Analysis Group, the Initiative for Digital Public Infrastructure at University of Massachusetts Amherst, and the School of Journalism at Northeastern University.

TERM	QUERY
transgender	transgender
trans	"trans man" OR "trans men" OR "trans woman" OR "trans women" OR "trans person" OR "trans people" OR "trans individual" OR "trans community"
genderfluid	"gender-fluid" OR genderfluid OR "gender fluid"
gender non conforming	"gender non-conforming" OR "gender non conforming" OR "gender nonconforming"
gender expansive	"gender-expansive" OR genderexpansive OR "gender expansive"
nonbinary	"non-binary" OR nonbinary OR "non binary"
gender identity	"gender identity"
gender ideology	"gender ideology"

Above: These are the identity terms identified by the TNI team and their corresponding queries.

VARIABLE	DESCRIPTION
id	A unique alphanumeric identifier for the article
indexed_date	The date the article was accessed via Media Cloud
language	All articles are tagged as "en" for English
media_name	The publication that published the article
media_url	The publication's URL
publish_date	The original publication date of the article
title	The article's headline
url	The article's URL
query	The original query term from the list above

Above: The listed information is available for every article in the dataset.

News articles were identified using a set of identity-related search terms from Media Cloud's "United States - National" collection, which includes over 240 sources. These sources include national-only publications as well as local publications with national audiences. A team of journalists, researchers, and subject matter experts manually selected the initial eight identity-related terms listed below, focusing specifically on trans communities and not broader LGBTQIA+ communities. The terms are listed next to their exact queries, which account for different stylization, spellings, and descriptors. Articles were considered a match if the query term appeared in the article's headline or body text, when available. Because of legal and technical constraints, this project surfaces article headlines, not full body text.

The team uses Python scripts to collect and process this data each month. Each article is included as a row in the data with the following properties.

ARTICLE CLASSIFICATION

Wire stories republished by multiple outlets were treated as individual articles instead of collapsed, prioritizing news dissemination and reach over unique reporting. Generic news round-ups and recaps (e.g., “Weekend Report”, “Top Stories”, “News Roundup”) were filtered from the event data. We then used the RoBERTa-base model to assign embeddings to each article headline, and employed these embeddings to cluster the output using HDBSCAN. The clusters were labelled using an LLM aimed at creating an umbrella cluster phrase from the individual article headlines in the same cluster.

Subsequently, we asked two teams of subject matter experts to manually label a selection of event clusters with the 13 overarching (non-exclusive) themes listed below. This created a sample of roughly 8,000 theme-labelled news articles, which were used to train a classifier that applied the overarching theme labels to all other news articles. We also created a review

THEME	DESCRIPTION
Resilience, resistance, & solutions	Public demonstrations, protests, pride events, and other acts of resilience and resistance
Anti-trans violence & hate	Dangerous and damaging acts directed at the trans community, including but not limited to: harassment, hate speech, and fatal violence
Trans youth & parental rights	The debate around parental rights and child autonomy – this includes conversations about data privacy, K-12 education policy, and conflicts between which parents' rules preside
Ideology & culture wars	Philosophical, moral, religious, and cultural arguments surrounding transgender communities
U.S. federal measures	Actions, policies, legislations, and rulings taken at the federal level by federal representatives – this includes rhetoric and threats, too
Censorship & free speech	Censorship of supportive trans-related speech and use of harmful anti-trans rhetoric under the guise of free speech
Health care & bodily autonomy	Access to healthcare and the ability to make one's own decisions in regard to gender affirming care, abortions, and other medical care
Trans & nonbinary identity	Both the celebration of identity through protective laws or personal experiences – and the suppression of it through measures such as laws restricting legal identification
Transnationality	International events and laws, transnational conversations about gender policy, and policies around trans migrants
Pop culture & creativity	Representation across pop culture, the arts, and other creative fields
Access to public space	The ability to exist in public regardless of how you identify – this includes the right to nondiscriminatory employment, bathroom access, marriage, voting, entertainment, and more
Trans people in sports	Gender inclusivity and bans in sports spanning youth, school, collegiate, professional, and Olympic levels
U.S. state measures	Actions, policies, legislations, and rulings taken at the state level or by state representatives

Above: The data has been divided into the 13 themes listed here. Pay attention to the descriptions of each theme for important context.

system that allowed for manual correction of event labels and themes. Event clusters were included in the beeswarm visualization if they had 10 or more related articles.

PUBLICATION POLITICAL LEAN

GROUND NEWS LEAN	MEDIA CLOUD TWITTER/X VOTER LEAN, 2018	MEDIA CLOUD TWITTER/X FOLLOWER LEAN, 2019	VALUE
Left	Tweeted more by Democratic voters	Tweeted more by followers of Liberal politicians	-2
Lean left	Tweeted somewhat more by Democratic voters	Tweeted somewhat more by followers of Liberal politicians	-1
Center	Tweeted evenly by Republican/Democratic voters, 2018	Tweeted evenly by followers of Conservative/Liberal politicians	0
Lean right	Tweeted somewhat more by Republican voters, 2018	Tweeted somewhat more by followers of Conservative politicians	1
Right	Tweeted more by Republican voters, 2018	Tweeted more by followers of Conservative politicians	2

Above: We used three different sources to help determine publication political leans, one of which aggregates multiple rating systems.

Below: These final leans are what's seen on the platform.

LEAN	VALUE
LEFT	< -1.5
LEAN LEFT	>= -1.5 and < -0.5
CENTER	>= -0.5 and <= 0.5
LEAN RIGHT	> 0.5 and <= 1.5
RIGHT	> 1.5

To capture a publication's political lean, we created an average lean by using Ground News' media bias rating, which aggregates leans from Ad Fontes Media, All Sides, and Media Bias/Fact Check, and Media Cloud's collections of publications tweeted by voters by political lean and tweeted by followers of politicians by political lean. Because this is done at the publication level, it does not reflect the political lean of individual coverage areas, sections, articles, reporters, or editors.

Each publication was assigned a value for each of the first 3 columns below. For example, CNN's media bias rating from Ground News was "Lean left" (-1), CNN was tweeted evenly by Republican/Democratic voters in 2018 (0), and CNN was tweeted somewhat more by followers of liberal politicians in 2019 (-1).

Those values were then summed and averaged, giving CNN an average value of -0.67. That average value was then mapped to the lean ranges seen below to determine political leans.

DATA HIGHLIGHTS

HIGHLIGHT ONE

BETWEEN JANUARY 2020 AND OCTOBER 2025, THE TRANS NEWS INITIATIVE IDENTIFIED MORE THAN 190,500 ARTICLES PUBLISHED ABOUT TRANS COMMUNITIES.

On average, more than 2,700 stories about trans communities were published each month. This shows that our stories are not fringe or one-off topics, but a regular part of news coverage. Journalists, media researchers, and others must embrace better practices that treat our lived experiences as a constant, not a curiosity.

HIGHLIGHT TWO

OF THE YEARS ANALYZED, THE HIGHEST NUMBER OF ARTICLES ABOUT TRANS COMMUNITIES WERE PUBLISHED IN 2023, TOTALING NEARLY 67,000 ARTICLES.

There was a major surge in articles about U.S. state government measures impacting trans communities in 2023, making the theme the most common of that year during which Florida Gov. Ron DeSantis made a bid for the 2024 Republican Presidential nomination. His campaign and policies against the trans community surfaced frequently in the headlines of articles.

HIGHLIGHT THREE

THE 2021 CONTROVERSY SURROUNDING DAVE CHAPPELLE WAS THE MOST WRITTEN-ABOUT EVENT CONCERNING TRANS COMMUNITIES FROM 2020-2025.

Noted comedian Dave Chappelle has a history of making jokes at the expense of the trans community dating back to at least 2017. In 2021, Chappelle created and released a comedy special with Netflix, which included an extensive performance of such content. Despite calls from other comedians, Netflix employees, and social justice advocates for Netflix to take down the special, the content remained on the streaming platform. Subsequent related actions, such as a Netflix employee walkout and the comedy special's two Emmy nominations, captured news attention for many months.

HIGHLIGHT FOUR

“POP CULTURE & CREATIVITY” WAS THE MOST COMMON ARTICLE THEME IN 2020, 2021, 2022, AND 2024, DEMONSTRATING HOW TRANS COMMUNITIES ARE PART OF EVERYDAY HUMAN EXPERIENCES.

From 2020-2025, about a quarter of all articles written about trans communities were themed “pop culture & creativity,” which included events such as singer Demi Lovato’s publicly sharing her pronouns and actor Elliot Page’s coming out as trans. The “popularity” of this theme reflects the increased visibility of trans people and gender expansiveness in culture; this also aligns with an increased vulnerability of our communities as manifested in the health care bans, bathroom restrictions, and other limits on our human rights we’re currently navigating.

HIGHLIGHT FIVE

DESPITE GOVERNMENT-RELATED EVENTS BEING MORE COMMON, POP CULTURE EVENTS RECEIVED MORE COVERAGE AND DOMINATED THE MEDIA LANDSCAPE.

Events concerning both “U.S. federal measures” and “U.S. state measures” impacting

the trans community individually outnumber those about “pop culture & creativity” – despite “pop culture & creativity” being the most common theme. An average of 221 articles were published per event within the “pop culture & creativity” theme. In comparison, about 135 articles were published per “U.S. state measures” event and just 123 articles were published per “U.S. federal measures” event during the same time frame.

HIGHLIGHT SIX

THE NUMBER OF ARTICLES ABOUT “U.S. FEDERAL MEASURES” THAT IMPACT TRANS COMMUNITIES MORE THAN DOUBLED FROM 2024 TO 2025.

In 2024, about 5,300 articles were published about “U.S. federal measures” impacting trans communities. The following year in 2025, more than 11,000 articles were published about the same theme. In 2024, there was an average of about 161 articles published per event, while in 2025 there was an average of just 70 articles published per event – less than half the coverage compared to the previous year. This demonstrates that though more events impacting trans communities can result in more total articles about us, the amount of news attention per event may decrease, especially amidst competing news priorities. Fewer articles per event means that media coverage moves on more quickly. Political measures may be less likely to receive the sustained attention necessary to inspire accountability for unjust or discriminatory actions.

HIGHLIGHT SEVEN

THE NUMBER OF ARTICLES WITHIN THE THEME “RESILIENCE, RESISTANCE, AND SOLUTIONS” LAGGED BEHIND OTHERS,

BECOMING THE LEAST COMMON THEME EVERY YEAR FROM 2021-2025.

News coverage largely focused on specific cultural happenings, government policies, and anti-trans violence and hate. At the same time, stories about hope, problem solving, and solidarity were often left behind. Not only was the theme of “resilience, resistance, & solutions” the least common by number of articles; it also had the fewest articles published per event of any theme, with an average of just 101 articles published per event from 2021-2025. Stories about how we have and are publicly resisting, including through protests, pride events, and other acts of resilience are, on the whole, deprioritized among national newsrooms. As a result, the examples of how we take care of ourselves, show up for community, and embody the lessons of our ancestors are not covered. This delays narrative change.

HIGHLIGHT EIGHT

THE HEADLINES OF ARTICLES PUBLISHED BY OUTLETS DEEMED TO BE ALIGNED WITH THE POLITICAL RIGHT TEND TO BE VERY NEGATIVE.

Coverage from left-leaning and center-aligned sources expressed a wide range of topics and tones, publishing both positive and negative narratives about trans communities. Within the coverage from right-aligned sources, article headlines were more often negative, using verbs such as “demands,” “ignore,” “pushes,” and “smears.” They also often focused on interpersonal conflicts, such as the tension between gymnast Simone Biles and former collegiate swimmer Riley Gaines about trans athletes in women’s sports or the resignation of the president of Texas A&M after a professor was fired for discussing gender identity in the classroom. This bias toward negative narratives and conflict-driven reporting demonstrates how political ideology seeps into reporting, including word choice and decisions about whether and how much to cover different news events.

AUDIENCE & UTILITIES

The Trans News Initiative's scope is intentionally broad. As a publicly-accessible tool, TNI strives for both educational and accountability goals: to help people better understand the shape and content of trans news coverage, and to illustrate who is making it; and to help make the work more efficient for those doing accountability and media analysis research. The possibilities are endless – and more will emerge with use.

FOR JOURNALISTS AND THEIR NEWSROOMS:

As the tool demonstrates, anti-trans measures have inundated legislatures – and as a result, newsrooms have needed to cover them. [Most journalists lack experience reporting on trans communities and the issues that impact us; TNI can be used by reporters and media makers to familiarize themselves with the coverage area.](#)

For smaller publications or independent journalists who focus on trans media representation and coverage, the Trans News Initiative can serve as an accountability tool tracking how the major newsrooms included within the data are covering trans lives, narrowing down by particular publication, story, or time period. Smaller newsrooms often require partnerships with local outlets to access resources for everything from fact-checking to art assets. Through the tool, those organizations can identify potential partners based on the tool's depiction of their political lean or existing track record of coverage.

For newsrooms seeking to increase or improve their coverage, the data provided by the Trans News Initiative can generate new story ideas and investigative reporting opportunities. [Journalists and other storytellers can also use the tool to identify what stories are not being told, and are being missed – providing a valuable opportunity for innovative work.](#)

FOR ACADEMICS AND RESEARCHERS:

The Trans News Initiative is an opportunity for those who study media trends and bias, trans communities, political polarization, and the treatment of marginalized communities to challenge or confirm assumptions for their work.

It may be used as a discovery tool for researchers seeking a database to identify stories on a certain topic; highlight other trends and themes within the data; build out their own research; or find new avenues of inquiry. If they are researching a particular story that is featured in the data set, they can explore a repository of how that story was treated at the time, sorted by bias or timeframe.

Professors in communications, journalism, gender and sexuality studies, and sociology disciplines can [use the Trans News Initiative as an educational tool in classes or coursework, encouraging students to build research projects around the data](#). The tool's visual format and built-in interactivity can be extremely effective for instructional purposes.

Those who study and research media trends can use the tool to produce an analysis of coverage of a particular event or issue by digging into the respective stories' contents.

FOR COMMUNITY ORGANIZERS AND ACTIVISTS:

Trans advocates in healthcare, sports, and every aspect of trans life are intensely aware of the shortcomings of media coverage. They are constantly seeking access to media outlets, and only some will feature their voices. [Organizers can use this data to strategically pitch underreported stories to competent, experienced journalists, or to motivate support of community-driven media which often fills such gaps](#).

The tool's filters for viewing coverage by date and political leaning allow organizers to monitor how different outlets frame issues impacting trans people, track trends in hostile coverage, and prepare responses for impending media cycles.

[TNI can also inform strategic communications and narrative change efforts](#) that challenge sensationalized coverage and advocate for more balanced reporting on policy impacts and community experiences.

EARLY LEARNINGS

Through internal and external feedback from journalists, researchers, and potential users, as well as trainings and professional development convenings with newsroom leaders across national, regional, and local publications, the TJA has begun to identify how the Trans News Initiative is currently being used. [These early learnings have helped clarify how the tool can be used by newsrooms with limited trans representation, and how it can support our broader goal of shifting news coverage and the narratives that shape public understanding.](#)

- Journalists, media researchers, and others must embrace better practices that treat the lived experiences of trans and gender expansive people as a constant, not a curiosity.
- Mainstream newsrooms want opportunities for professional development and continuing education they can trust, especially on best practices for covering issues that impact trans people. The TJA, with the Trans News Initiative and our other programs, will continue to provide these opportunities and resources.
- The TNI tool is especially useful for newsrooms with limited resources, such as regional outlets, local newsmedia, and independent LGBTQ+ publications. The dataset is a prime starting place for accountability journalism targeting more resourced, mainstream newsrooms as well as the broader industry.
- One action, like the 2021 comedy special from Dave Chappelle, for example, can cascade into media coverage (negative and positive) about trans communities across many topics, including pop culture, the politics of speech, corporate ethics, resistance movements, and more.
- Trans people and our communities feel unable to rely on mainstream media to accurately report on our lives, let alone the impact of proposed and passed legislation on our rights. The TNI tool is a starting place for discussing how to build and increase community trust in media.

FUTURE DEVELOPMENT OPPORTUNITIES

Ongoing feedback has also surfaced clear opportunities to expand and deepen the Initiative's utility, usability, and reach. [These growth points will guide future updates of the tool.](#)

- Assessing a publication's "factualness," or how often it peddles misinformation or disinformation, was identified as a potential development to build upon the political lean meter. Such an inclusion could further contextualize the full dataset within the broader media crisis and aid efforts to build media trust by equipping consumers with a metric that spotlights the reliability news consumers desire from their news.
- Incorporating geographic and place-based mechanisms. This could allow the characterization of newsroom coverage by regions and comparative analyses of national and regional reporting.
- Supplementing TNI resources with external analysis of which news coverage quotes trans sources and how often would help evaluate a publication's source diversity. It could also reveal strategic possibilities for community organizers and others engaged in the work of narrative change.
- Broadening the data to include LGBTQ+ publications and other smaller independent outlets would help identify where and how coverage differs from the mainstream.
- The news media ecosystem is vast. Broadening data to include coverage from platforms excluded from the initial product, such as broadcast news, print publications that may not have a digital edition, independent newsletters and zines, podcasts, and other forms of new media would increase the tool's utility, and provide a more holistic view.

Establishing new partnerships with data analysis organizations could help the project expand and have greater impact. Relationships and technologies that allow us to successfully navigate copyright and other related restrictions would support more granular analyses beyond headlines.

TRANS NEWS INITIATIVE COLLABORATORS



The Trans Journalists Association is a nonprofit professional membership organization that promotes accurate, nuanced coverage of trans rights and communities in the media and fosters the careers of gender-expansive journalists. Its contributors to the Trans News Initiative and this white paper include Tre'vell Anderson, Tat Bellamy-Walker, Gina Chua, C.D. Davidson-Hiers, Minami Funakoshi, Graph Massara, Lex McMenamin, Kae Petrin, and Emilia Ruzicka.



The University of Miami School of Communication is committed to developing forward-thinking, analytical, and ethical communication professionals. Their undergraduate and graduate programs integrate theory with practice, emphasizing creativity, collaboration, and independent thinking. Faculty at the School champion freedom of expression, guiding future scholars, professionals, and leaders toward a lifetime of service and learning. Its contributors to the Trans News Initiative and this white paper include Dr. Ayleen Cabas-Mijares and Dr. Alberto Cairo.

Polygraph

Polygraph is a studio composed of the same team behind *The Pudding*. They're an in-house data journalism team, with an eye for translating complex information into visual content.